



Ecosystems are a complex mixture of living things and their habitat, with different species interacting with each other like the pieces in a jigsaw puzzle. Usually an ecosystem has enough resources to sustain all the species, but if something changes it can *affect the balance* of the whole system.

Natural catastrophes are rare, sudden events, but the *effect of humans* is continuous and often more destructive. We humans are *taking over larger and larger areas* of the land for our own needs, *destroying* existing *habitats*. And the oceans are not safe, either.



Human intervention...

DEFORESTATION



Prairie dogs are useful in their natural environment, but farmers do not like their tunnels and they have almost been wiped out in parts of the United States. This had consequences for black-footed ferrets, whose main food is prairie dogs—they almost became extinct. A breeding program has now boosted their numbers.



SHAPING THE ENVIRONMENT

Some species play a key role in shaping and maintaining the environment. Prairie dogs dig burrows that provide homes for many other species, including burrowing owls and black-footed ferrets. Their tunnels help break up the soil and trap rainwater. They also trim the grass, removing cover for predators.